

"Courageous, clear-eyed, and utterly compelling."

—KRISTIN KOBES DU MEZ

MATTHEW D. TAYLOR

DEFYING

TYRANTS

FOLLOWING JESUS IN A WORLD
OF CHRISTIAN ANTICHRISTS

Defying Tyrants

AUGSBURG FORTRESS
PUBLISHERS
NOT FOR RESALE

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Broadleaf Books
Minneapolis

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INTRODUCTION

I HAVE SPENT the last twenty years observing the rapid spread of several new invasive species of Christianity. These noxious, fast-growing weeds are trendy theologies taking over more and more of the Christian garden. They're all forms of Christian supremacy: a dangerous vision of Christian power that turns believers into bullies and abusers.

Christian supremacy is the belief that Christians are better than other people and are therefore entitled to power. Unlike the most well-known teachings of Christ, Christian supremacy teaches Christians to fear their neighbors, persecute their enemies, and conquer the world. It is authoritarian in both its politics and its leadership model.

And Christian supremacy is not just growing in one little corner of the Christian garden. New species of it are emerging within and swiftly taking root in large swaths of contemporary evangelicalism, Pentecostalism, broader Protestantism, Catholicism, and Orthodoxy too. The whole field is getting overgrown with these aggressive weeds. There are different variants and strands, with different theologies used to justify each. But these obsessions with Christian power are corrupting countless communities, ensnaring millions of Christians, and harming Christians and non-Christians alike. All forms of Christian supremacy bastardize the gospel of Jesus by convincing Christians they are building the kingdom of God while they are actually doing the opposite—harming people in Jesus's name.

In this book I speak as a Christian, from within the Christian tradition, and argue against Christian supremacy using the most fundamental sources of our tradition: Jesus, the Christian scriptures, and the witness of the early church. Truly facing this rash of invasive species today—these modern forms of Christian supremacy—also requires that we face the past, because Christian supremacy has very deep roots. In truth, Christianity has always been a weedy garden. So we will dig into the long history of Christians abusing political power as well in order to understand where these modern manifestations come from.

I'm not the first one to warn about this. Many experts are speaking up. And you don't even have to consult the experts: Many Christians today sense a darkening theological horizon, storm clouds gathering of a sort we haven't seen before, at least not in a long, long time. Antisemitism, hatred of Muslims, hostility to migrants and refugees, misogyny, and overt racism are finding more purchase within Christian communities.

Perhaps you picked up this book because you've seen evidence of the vigorous growth of Christian supremacy up close: filling your social media feed, ripping through your church, splintering your family. What are we to do, as Christians, about the spread of power-hungry theologies and the abusive leaders within our communities who are doing so much damage in our world?

I hold no recognizable office in the church. I'm not a pastor or a priest or a bishop. I don't belong to the guild of professional theologians. I am a lay leader in the Christian community, a parishioner, an invested member, a regular pew-sitter, a brother. This book is participating in an internal debate, a fight among Christians, a family spat. We can have our other family rivalries and theological debates, our perennial family quarrels, another time. Right now, we need to pull the whole community together for a different kind of conversation. Right now, we must speak bluntly, as Christians among Christians.

If you are not a Christian, you are more than welcome to read along and listen in. I have learned much from eavesdropping on theological conversations among Jewish rabbis and scholars and Muslim imams, shaykhs, and shaykhas. I have even learned things about God from atheists.

Christian theology does not merely affect Christians. The peril of Christian supremacy reaches far beyond a few hundred extremist preachers, monomaniacal pastors, and abusive priests who snag the headlines with their scandals. It reaches to the heights of power in America and in the world, to the wannabe authoritarians who would invoke the name of God and bless the name of Jesus even as they mercilessly torture migrants, ignore or arm or fund genocidal wars, build financial empires that elevate the ultrarich to godlike status, dominate others through slavery in all but name, and cut off needed aid to starving people for sport.

This book is titled *Defying Tyrants* because I am calling us back to the assumption of the early church: that Christians of good conscience and a

sincere desire to follow the way of Jesus Christ should denounce and loathe all authoritarian abuses of power, whether inside the church or outside it.

Some theological fights are worth having. This one is of utmost importance and urgency, because the very message and beauty of the gospel of Jesus are being poisoned by these foul power schemes that masquerade as being aligned with Christ.

This is a theological emergency.

Many Churches, One Problem

I am a wanderer down many avenues, a sojourner through many forms of Christianity. I have belonged to just about every style of church you can name offhand. Evangelical, mainline, Baptist, Presbyterian, Anglican, historically Black, Pentecostal: They have all formed me. I'm a real Protestant mutt.

In all these churches I have met bona fide saints: exemplary, holy people. People who listen kindly, give generously, perform menial tasks without thinking of their dignity, and humbly love the lowest and the poorest. They rarely grace the big stage of the church or post their deeds on social media, preferring to serve behind the scenes. I could tell you their names, but you've never heard of them. Yet they reek of godliness, in the best sense of that word, because they are imitating Jesus.

In part by focusing on such exemplars, in my Christian youth I nurtured the idea that Christianity wasn't like other religions. The church was full of good people: imperfect people, no doubt, but all in the process of being redeemed, right? Christianity was this beautiful, correct, and logical thing, a walled garden of truth and goodness. It seemed sad (and, frankly, perplexing) that the rest of the world hadn't acknowledged or accepted our truth yet. Other religions and ideologies were abusive and violent, authoritarian and legalistic, but Christianity had a gospel—a "good tidings" message—of grace, freedom, love, dignity, peace, and justice. Hence Christianity had spread by proclamation, not the sword.

I felt that effortless sense of superiority that so many people feel about their homeland or hometown or home team: How did I get so lucky to be born into the best religion and raised in the true faith? I sang along heartily with the hymns and worship songs about conquering the world for Jesus.

Then I got educated: both by living in the church and by studying in the classroom. I met people from around the world who told me stories that pierced my middle-class, white, male, American Christian bubble. They gave me eyes to see. Ears to hear.

I also met some of those wolves in sheep's clothing that Jesus warned us about. Some days, in fact, I worry that more than half of the shepherd's flock is just wolves in drag. In every church I have been part of, I've seen abusive behavior cloaked as spiritual wisdom. I've seen—more than once—how the church sausage is made. I have known the petty rivalries and subtle tyrannies that stalk the halls of your average neighborhood church. I've observed the good ol' boys networks, the pastoral dictatorships, the so-wealthy-they're-entitled-to-be-opinionated elders, the quietly unabashed racism, and the string of minor scandals that only a select few in that church will ever know about.

I have seen the Christian missionaries using aggressive tactics and exploiting needed humanitarian aid to make the conversion numbers, so that the faithfully donating churches back home would stay happy and keep forking over the cash. And I have encountered the legacy of Christian empires: that not-so-distant era when European and North American monarchies and bureaucracies and churches divided up the globe into exploited colonies like the soldiers throwing dice for Christ's garments.

I've seen the Christian racism, the casual comments and furtive glances in your everyday church but also the out-of-the-closet Christian racists. I've watched neo-Nazis, white supremacists, Klansmen, hate preachers, and racist demonizers proudly name Jesus as their Lord and Savior and attribute their hatred to him.

I've heard from Christian women, locked in cycles of abuse or devaluation, barred from having their voices count equally in the church, particularly women whose skin isn't white like mine. I've kept a wary eye on that unending parade of Christian leaders burning up the headlines with their sexual and spiritual abuse scandals, supposedly godly men (and on rare occasions women) who have acted in ways that have shocked even the irreligious and morally tolerant.

I've met Christian children raised in abusive homes: sometimes physical abuse, sometimes sexual, sometimes spiritual, sometimes all of the above. I've known Christian parents who have professed piety and the name of Jesus

as a cause to reject their own children, to cut ties with their own kin over politics or sexuality or theological differences.

I've witnessed the inner workings of the Christian political machine, the Christian leaders and politicians using an exclusionary appeal to "God's people" to advance their own agenda of self-aggrandizement and dominance. I have lived through the wars and foreign-policy disasters around the globe that are ginned up in the name of Christ so that human beings—many of them Christians themselves—are starved or displaced or murdered, sometimes all of the above.

I've watched the Christian music industrial complex and countless pop preachers treat militarism as a virtue and patriarchal tyranny as God's foremost attribute. I've listened to their violence-besotted words, the lyrics that are warping Christians' imaginations around power and control. And I've seen the Christian hucksters and schemers and televangelists soaking the faithful for all they're worth.

I served as an evangelical Christian minister for almost a decade, working with college students on university campuses. I loved the work. We studied Scripture, talked about Jesus, preached the gospel, and tried to do some good. Teaching the Bible, helping students get to know the utterly unique person of Jesus, I felt something come alive in me. I saw lives changed. I met many more saints—radical, selfless people who earnestly wanted to follow Jesus and be good neighbors.

But the longer I worked for my ministry organization, the more I saw a new, assertive "growth mentality" starting to take over. I began getting hounded by my supervisors, who were being hounded by theirs: What are your numbers? How many conversions this month? Are we growing? How many new leaders do you have?

We *said* that converting people was God's business. We *said* that our part was just to be faithful. But we sure did have a lot of methods of trying to force God's hand, produce growth, make those conversion numbers, and set more aggressive goals. I started to get this hard-to-shake feeling that our *growth mentality* was actually just a desire to be bigger and better.

Pretty soon edicts began coming down from on high: We're taking sides in the culture wars, going from a commune mindset to a bunker mindset. There were new rules for what people had to believe and who had to be

excluded. I had friends who got hurt because their sexuality or their politics or their culture didn't match the new mandate.

I also got educated in the classroom. I sensed that something was wrong in these churches and in my ministry organization, with all these persistent power abuses. So I threw myself into studying at a Protestant seminary alongside the next generation of pastors and missionaries.

We were taught the history of Christianity and Christian theological traditions, but there is a terrifying side to that history, a side that I'll narrate some in the first two chapters, that we mostly avoided. We locked it in a box, bracketed the ugly stories of political exploitation and violence that haunt the history of the growth of the Christian church. Instead, we studied the ideas, the theology of it, pretending that the ideas themselves were detachable from the blood shed in their name.

I came to find out that some really treacherous characters—veritable Christian extremists who are harming and radicalizing Christian people to this day—had also graduated from and even taught at my reputedly very mainstream seminary. But we never talked about them. They were gone by my time, so why think about that foul bit of institutional history or how they came to their extremism?

And inching along in the background of my seminary education, I observed more subtle conceptions of Christian entitlement creeping their way into my school and among my colleagues. Some of these were taught in classes: fancy and formal ideas framed with academic respectability and big vocabulary flourishes. Some of these were more down-to-earth devotional ideas: If we are God's children, doesn't God want us to be wealthy and healthy and beautiful and strong? If we Christians have the Truth, with a capital T, why shouldn't we take a guiding hand in society and shape the laws and the government around it? We have the Bible, so shouldn't justice be whatever we say it is? Isn't the mission of the church to fix the world?

I left my Protestant seminary to study theology and religion at a Catholic university, hoping to find among the sturdy scholarship and deep memory of the Catholic tradition a way to describe and understand these invasive visions of Christian supremacy. As I studied with my Catholic professors and talked with my Catholic friends—some priests, some laypeople, some conservative, some liberal—I found many more Christians full of godliness

and generosity. But they also told me stories of disillusioning hierarchies and systemic distortions of power within their church. I heard them tell of the vengeful theologies and militant leaders ascendant among Catholics too. Here was simply another locale, another tradition in which a fast-growing fixation with Christian power was surging.

Wanting to go yet deeper, I got a PhD in the theology of radical religious movements—Muslim and Christian—and I became a scholar researching and writing about contemporary Christian radicalization and extremism. I went from being a minister, confused by these theologies of Christian power hooking and twisting their way into my churches, ministry organization, and seminary, to becoming an expert in identifying and describing each encroaching species.

In the past few years, I've created podcast series and written books and given hundreds of media interviews and lectures about the movements I study: their extreme ideas, their political radicalization, their theologies, and how they are related to the violence and authoritarian political shifts we see in our news headlines.

In just about every church or Christian institution I have inhabited, the problem of Christians feeling entitled to power seemed to be getting worse, especially around politics. This is a book that tries to reckon with that problem *theologically*. Most humans want to relish the good and beautiful parts of our traditions. But desperate times call for desperate measures. And these are desperate times.

So we'll begin there—our desperate times.

The Identifying Markers of Christian Supremacy

I'm certain that by now a sizable fraction of you are skimming along with one eyebrow raised. *Christian supremacy, really?* You might be thinking, *OK, sure, some Christians are a little power hungry. They might say some borderline racist or xenophobic things. They might let their politics get out of hand. They might vote for politicians who delight in cruelty in Christ's name. But they're not like white supremacists. They're not like Islamic terrorists or something. Let's not get carried away.*

I get that response a lot. We live in hyperbolic times when commentary is cheap and it's easy to disclaim experts you disagree with as “politically

motivated” or “just someone who hates Christianity.” But as a religion researcher, whose job is keeping track of the thorny and fast-growing theologies behind extreme religious ideas, I can tell you that there is cause for alarm.

My day job involves monitoring the constantly morphing, real-time growth of Christian supremacy. What has shocked me, as I’ve both observed my own Protestant garden bed and peeked over the hedgerows into my Catholic and Orthodox neighbors’ plots, is the accelerating and out-of-control spread of Christian supremacy among Christians around the globe. I have seen the rising face of Christian evil.

So what constitutes Christian supremacy, and why is it so dangerous?

Christian supremacy, at its most basic, is the idea that Christians are entitled to power over other people. It is represented by an ever-growing array of species and forms. Christian supremacy can appear, at first bloom, as a sort of fear and paranoia: an exaggeration of one’s enemies and the peril they pose. In their own minds, Christian supremacists are always the good guys or the victims, even when they are the ones inflicting harm and abuse, so they must exaggerate and caricature their opponents and lie about their own real-world victims to make them all seem truly evil.

Even if it wears a “loving” face, Christian supremacy seeks to coerce and dominate—including, frequently, people who bear the Christians no ill will. Jesus paradigmatically taught us to be humble, generous neighbors and to love our enemies. But a signal attribute of Christian supremacy is a sense of innate superiority over enemy and non-Christian neighbor alike. Christian supremacists persecute and aim to destroy and eradicate their enemies.

Politically today, Christian supremacists are the shock troops detonating democracy for the sake of building new authoritarian states. They are magnetized to dictatorial leaders because they need a path to power and they know their agenda is unpopular and would almost certainly never be voted in freely by a majority in a functioning democracy. Christian supremacists are closely tied to Christian nationalists—those who believe that *their nation* is especially Christian—and often work shoulder to shoulder with them. But Christian supremacy is a *global* domination scheme. It aims for nothing less than a whole-world conquest by Christianity.

If that sounds far-fetched to you, I'd recommend you read my previous book, *The Violent Take It by Force*, in which I track a set of these global leaders and show how they were radicalized, including some of them at that seminary I attended. Christian supremacists want to impose their strict moral code on their neighbors—even if they themselves frequently violate that moral code with impunity. They are fond of citing a selective set of biblical passages that fit their agenda of restricting their neighbors' freedoms and rights. But their hermeneutic avoids, with surgical precision, Jesus's essential teachings about power and its abuses. It skirts around the earliest Christians' revolutionary practices of human equality, radical hospitality, and voluntary self-denial.

Christian supremacists preach obedience to tyrants. If no tyrant is immediately available, they counsel a political mobilization—and, if need be, a conspiracy to overthrow an insufficiently Christian government—all to make society Christian at any cost. When society is dominated by Christianity, they promise, all will be at peace and all abuses of power will cease. They paper over the sickening history of Christian tyrants, Christian empires, and Christian holy wars.

Christian supremacists are characteristically proud of—even zealous for—Christianity and will go to great lengths to preserve, protect, and expand Christianity's privileged place in society. But they tend to hold in contempt actual Christians, at least those who don't belong to their particular clan. Christianity is their ideal, their cause, their absolute. Actual Christians are the messy, inconvenient, imperfect, embodied reality, so Christian supremacists surgically sculpt and present an idealized, muscular Christianity. In the process, they make all but invisible the foul side of Christian history and the bodies left in Christian supremacy's wake.

It's easy to look at this problem and imagine it to be primarily *political*, just human beings selfish for more power. If this were true, then it would merely need to be resisted in the political realm as a political force. But make no mistake: Christian supremacy is also profoundly theological. Many humans are attracted to power and embrace the will to dominate for many reasons. In fact, what makes Christian supremacy distinct, among all the varied, nasty supremacies of our modern world, is its theological nature. It is precisely Christian supremacy's theological toxicity that makes interventions

like this book and other jeremiads, books, and sermons necessary. We must resist it both in the public square and in our churches.

Because one must first have power to abuse it, Christian supremacists tend to find their way into leadership. They deftly climb the structures of the church, rising to positions of prominence and respect. Many of them become youth leaders, worship leaders, elders, deacons, pastors, revival preachers, priests, teachers, bishops, activists, apostles, prophets, and politicians. They are celebrated for their knowledge, their piety, their innovative preaching, their ready biblical quotations. They grace the stages of the major Christian conferences and write bestselling Christian books and record bestselling Christian albums. But, to borrow from Jesus's wise imagination, big-time Christianity is like a whitewashed tomb: pleasant enough on the outside, yes, but on the inside full of revolting stench and buried skeletons.

Christian supremacists don't make up a majority of the church—God be praised!—but they do wield an outsized influence on Christianity. They are motivated to claim and steer and build Christianity, frequently at the expense of a lot of real-world Christians and almost always in rebellion against Jesus's explicit teachings.

As we've already noted, different species of Christian supremacy plague different host habitats, attaching themselves to different forms of Christianity. Hyperactive Christian nationalism is a sort of brash, chauvinistic version, blending a blood-and-soil nativism with a cultural holy war. Some Catholics have named their aberrant, invasive power-species "integralism" or "radical traditionalism," a vision that is literally medieval in how it calibrates the relationship of church and state. It is termed *phyletism* among the Orthodox: the elevation of a select set of Christians to premier status. Some Protestants call it *dominion theology* or *dominionism*—a hope for Christian power over the whole globe. Others talk of Christians as the ruling *Ekklesia* and "conquering the Seven Mountains" (family, government, religion, education, arts and entertainment, media, business) in every society. Still others call it *theonomy*: the ambition for Christians to use biblical law to restructure modern nations. These are all variations on a theme of Christian empowerment and Christian entitlement.

If, as you are reading these descriptions of Christian supremacy, you are calling to mind some celebrity Christians you know, some dynamic and

provocative leaders you have a half interest in, then you're someone they want to enlist in their militant Christianity. They will say they want to empower you, to strengthen Christianity, to battle immorality—awful, decadent, caricatured in its wickedness—because good Christians can't tolerate such heathen ways. They will offer you theologies that promise prosperity, protection from the wicked world, power for you and your community, maybe even a way for you to climb the ladder. They will offer you a government that will empower Christians, a government that mouths solemn pieties while trampling your enemies. They will promise you all the kingdoms of this world.

But that was always a devil's bargain (Matthew 4:5–7, Luke 4:5–8). Jesus did not teach his followers to abuse power. Quite the opposite. Jesus instructed his followers to deny themselves and not to seek coercive power over others, and the New Testament churches' cardinal values were centered on living counterculturally sacrificial and generous lives.

In fact, the building of hierarchies of human value and power was a major topic and theme for Jesus and the New Testament churches, existing as they did in the profoundly tyrannical culture of the Roman Empire. In concepts and phrases that they memorialized in the gospels, epistles, and apocalyptic literature (passages that we so easily recite, trivialize, and take for granted two millennia hence), the New Testament communities staked out a radical and counterintuitive vision of a world stripped of hierarchies of human value and dignity. The early church anticipated and endeavored to live out the idea that “the last shall be first”: that the weak, powerless, and distressed victims of a brutal empire will be lifted up. They also claimed that “the first shall be last”: the rich and politically powerful will be brought lower.

Indeed, one of the most remarkable things about Jesus and the church of the first century was their stalwart opposition to the authoritarianism of their day. Jesus himself died the death of a political dissident against Roman tyranny on the cross, and the model of Jesus put some steel in the spine of Jesus's followers to resist the coercive persecution of the Roman Empire.

Instead of a mad scramble for more power, the early churches catechized and taught people not to seek self-promotion but instead to pursue what one writer calls “the renunciation of status.” They talked about how God, the one, high God, had descended not merely to become human but

to assume the lowest position of the subjugated and colonized victim of empire in order to overthrow all the empires of this world. While Caesar may dominate your body, they preached, Jesus can liberate you from Caesar's whole system.

If anything, it was the New Testament churches' practice of defying tyrants—of refusing to conform to Roman conceptions of power—that got the early Christians in so much trouble. Theology, done rightly, can be the most subversive activity on earth.